

The Universe includes everything that exists. Its scale defies imagination. Even travelling at light-speed, it would take billions of years to cross the part of the Universe we can see. Matter in the Universe is clumped into galaxies that float together in giant groups called superclusters. Our Milky Way, which contains the Sun and Earth, is a typical galaxy.

We can only see out as far as 13.8 billion light years, but the Universe probably extends much further

The Universe contains **more stars than sand grains** on Earth's beaches.

Stars make up the Milky Way, with some gas and dust thinly spread between them

The Sun is a fairly typical star. Many stars probably have a family of planets, like our Solar System.

Local stars

The nearest star to the Sun is about 4.2 light years away.

Solar System

Earth belongs to a family of other planets and rocky objects that orbit the Sun.

Earth

Our world is a small, rocky planet travelling through the vastness of space.

What is space?